THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #010

DANNY POSTMA TRIED FOUR IDEAS IN SIX MONTHS. ONE OF THEM STUCK

A Dutch founder who says he hates marketing checks what people are searching for before he builds anything. That habit led him to AI headshots, a business that now says it has taken more than $10 million. He stopped sharing his revenue in 2023, so we have pieced together what can be known.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Danny Postma, Founder
COMPANY	HeadshotPro
FOUNDED	2023
HQ	Undisclosed (third-party data lists a Singapore company, Postcrafts, as operator)
SECTOR	AI headshot generator
STAGE	Bootstrapped, small team
FUNDING	None reported
MODEL	One-time purchases for individuals, credits for company teams

Hello again, and welcome to File #010. Thank you for reading.

In the first weeks of HeadshotPro, in the spring of 2023, Danny Postma would go to bed and his servers would fall over while he slept. Customers on the other side of the world paid for their photos and got nothing, and by morning there was a queue of complaints waiting.

A few months later he flew home to the Netherlands for two weeks and barely looked at the business. Refunds went out automatically. His wife answered the support inbox for a couple of hours each morning. The money kept arriving.

This file is about how he got from the first situation to the second, and about a simple habit that explains most of his success: he looks at what people are typing into Google before he writes a line of code. It's also a slightly unusual file, because Danny decided in 2023 that his revenue was nobody's business. "I don't share revenue anymore," he told an interviewer. "Sorry." So we'll show you what the company says, what others estimate, and how far the

two agree. (All figures are in US dollars.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Danny Postma, a Dutch founder who has been building small internet products since he was 21, and who sold his first AI company in 2021.
- **What:** HeadshotPro. Upload about fifteen selfies, and an AI returns a set of professional-looking headshots in different outfits and backdrops. Individuals pay once. Companies buy them for whole teams.
- **Why it matters:** it shows how to grow a business on search traffic and affiliates when you don't like marketing and don't want to pay for ads.
- **The number to remember:** four. That's how many ideas he tried in roughly six months before one worked.

THE FOUNDER

Danny started in 2015, at 21, with a site called Landingfolio: a gallery of well-designed landing pages for people who build websites. It was built on WordPress and, by his own account, it was hard to make money from.

His second act went much better. He built Headlime, a tool that helped people write marketing copy. Then he got into the first batch of outside developers given access to GPT-3, the model that came before ChatGPT, and Headlime became one of the earliest AI writing products anywhere.

He sold it in March 2021, about eight months after launch. Indie Maker List says the buyer was Conversion.ai, the company later renamed Jasper, and the price was "seven figures". By Danny's own account it was over a million dollars. Headlime was making about $20,000 a month at the time.

His reason for selling tells you a lot about him. He told Arvid Kahl on the Bootstrapped Founder podcast that he'd had three options: raise money from investors, keep bootstrapping and hire a team, or sell. Two buyers were interested. And he didn't want to manage people.

HOW HE CHOOSES WHAT TO BUILD

Most founders come up with an idea and then work out how to find customers. Danny works the other way round.

"I only build products where there's SEO," he said on that podcast. SEO is search engine optimisation, the craft of appearing near the top of Google. Before he builds anything he opens Ahrefs, a tool that shows how many people search for a phrase each month and how hard it would be to rank for it. If plenty of people are searching and the competition is weak, he builds. If nobody's searching, he doesn't.

He does it this way because, in his words, he hates marketing. Search traffic is marketing you only have to do once. If your page answers the question someone typed, they arrive on their own, month after month, for free.

FOUR IDEAS IN SIX MONTHS

In September 2022 a model called Stable Diffusion was released. It could generate images from text, and for the first time anyone could build on it. Danny moved straight away. He described the sequence in a 2024 interview.

1. **Stock AI.** AI-generated stock photos. He liked a domain name for it, but the owner wanted $25,000 to $30,000, so he rented it at about $500 a month with an option to buy. He also worried about the legal risk around image rights. After three months and $1,500 the product hadn't caught on, so he walked away from both.
2. **ProfilePicture.AI.** Built in about 30 hours. It sold well for a week and then slowed.
3. **Deep Agency.** A "virtual modelling agency". Journalists loved writing about it, and almost nobody bought it.
4. **HeadshotPro.** Launched in March 2023, alongside Deep Agency. In his words it was "an instant hit". Secondary sites report about $100,000 in the first two weeks.

It would be easy to conclude that the fourth idea was the clever one. We'd put it differently. He had a way of testing each idea that cost a few weeks and a few hundred dollars, and he was willing to drop three of them. Deep Agency had press coverage and HeadshotPro had sales, and he followed the sales.

He then narrowed further. Competitors were branching into dating-profile photos and cartoon avatars. He stayed with one job: a headshot you could put on LinkedIn or a company website.

THE DOMAIN NAME

He paid $3,000 for headshotpro.com.

For a product with no customers that might seem a lot. His argument is that a strong, obvious .com helps you rank in search and stops a competitor from picking up people who half-remember your name. Remember that a few months earlier he had refused to pay $25,000 for a domain on an idea he hadn't proven. With Stock AI he rented the name and tested the idea first. With HeadshotPro the idea had already worked on a smaller scale, so he bought the name outright.

He also bought some older, related websites, such as profilepicturemaker.com, which already had visitors. He added a banner to each one pointing to HeadshotPro, and so picked up their existing traffic.

THE SECOND ENGINE

Search was the first source of customers. The second was affiliates.

An affiliate programme pays people a commission for every customer they send you. A blogger writes “the 7 best AI headshot tools”, links to you with a tracked link, and earns a share of each sale.

HeadshotPro runs its programme through a tool called Rewardful, and Rewardful has published a case study about it. That study says the programme brings in more than $50,000 a month and accounts for over 15 percent of HeadshotPro’s revenue. The caveats are that it’s written by the vendor, has no date on it and doesn’t say how many affiliates there are.

Danny’s reasoning is the useful part. Bloggers and reviewers need a reason to write about you, he says, and without a commission, far fewer would. Their articles also link to his site, which helps his search ranking. So the affiliates feed the search traffic as well as bringing in sales themselves.

THE SUMMER IT TRIPLED

Then he had some luck. In the summer of 2023 a phone app called Remini went viral with AI-generated professional photos, and for a few weeks it seemed everyone was posting them.

Millions of people went to Google and typed “AI headshots”. The site at the top of the results was HeadshotPro. “My sales have been tripled since that day,” he said.

He didn’t cause that wave. But he’d spent months making sure that if one came, he would be where it landed.

WHAT IT COST HIM

That same interview has a section we think is worth reading in full, because founders rarely say these things on the record.

He described being mentally unable to build new features, and going three weeks without making anything. He counted about five serious competitors and said he felt anxious about more arriving. He said he was “really nervous” about launching a plan for company teams. A first attempt at hiring someone in Europe had failed because the time difference ate into his rest.

So in the same months that the business was tripling, the person running it was struggling. Both things were true.

SOLO, AND THEN NOT

In August 2023 he still called himself a solopreneur, with his wife helping for two or three hours a day. But he had just posted his first job advert, for a machine learning engineer, and was studying how companies like Gumroad and Notion run remote teams.

By early 2024 he had a “small team”, starting with contractors and part-timers. He told Unite.AI that fear of hiring and managing people had kept him automating alone for too long, and that he should have built a team sooner. That’s the same man who sold Headlime to avoid managing anyone.

Today, third-party directories list the company at somewhere between one and ten people, operated by a Singapore company called Postcrafts. We couldn’t confirm the headcount. But the website now offers single sign-on, data-processing agreements and SOC 2 Type II security compliance for teams of 1,000 or more, and it names HubSpot’s sales team as a customer. One person and a helpful spouse don’t usually offer those things.

HOW THE PRODUCT WORKS

Most rivals, Danny says, take Stable Diffusion and retrain it on each customer’s photos, and leave it there. He says HeadshotPro runs “dozens” of additional models, some open-source and some its own, and that the team spent about a year building custom ones. He named two. One checks the photos people upload and filters out anything inappropriate in the results. The other cleans up the warped eyes and odd skin that AI faces are prone to.

About fifteen to seventeen input photos is, he says, the magic number.

The company’s own About page is candid on one point. It says the output only became good enough for everyday professional use in early 2025, which is nearly two years after it started selling.

A review by BetterPic, which sells a rival product and says so, rated HeadshotPro 7 out of 10 and reported some distortions, such as blurry eyes and odd fingers, in a share of the images. Bear in mind who wrote it.

THE NUMBERS

WHAT	CLAIM	WHO SAYS SO
Revenue since launch	More than $10 million	The company's About page
Customers	More than 250,000	The company's home page
Headshots generated	More than 17 million	The company
Satisfaction	96.7 percent satisfied and 3.3 percent refunded, across 217,879 purchases from 2023 to 2026	The company
Price	$29 for 30 headshots, up to $59 for 70. Team discounts of 20 to 50 percent	The company
Monthly revenue	About $300,000	Third-party estimates, widely repeated
Affiliate programme	More than $50,000 a month, over 15 percent of revenue	Rewardful, the vendor

Since Danny won't tell us, we did some arithmetic. This is ours and he hasn't confirmed any of it.

If $50,000 is 15 percent of monthly revenue, the total would be about $330,000 a month. That is close to the $300,000 estimate that circulates. And 217,879 purchases at between $29 and $59 each comes to somewhere between $6 million and $13 million, which brackets the $10 million the company claims.

That makes three weak sources that roughly agree. It doesn't prove anything, but figures that had been invented would be unlikely to line up this neatly.

WHAT MADE IT POSSIBLE

- **A sale behind him.** The Headlime money meant he could try four ideas without worrying about rent.
- **Years of SEO practice.** Landingfolio, his first site, was itself an exercise in getting found on Google.
- **A cheap way to test ideas,** and a willingness to drop the ones that didn't sell.
- **Narrow focus.** He sold professional headshots and didn't branch out.

Try this

Search before you build. Type the thing you want to sell into Google the way a customer would. Use a keyword tool (several have free versions) to see how many people search for it each month. If the answer is almost none, you'll need another way to find customers, so plan it now.

Run cheap tests with an end date. Give each idea a deadline and a sales target before you start. Danny rented a domain for $500 a month and stopped paying after three months.

Follow the sales, not the applause. One of his ideas got the press and another got the customers. Know which of those you're measuring.

Pay people to write about you. If you sell online, set up a simple affiliate programme early. A commission gives reviewers a reason to cover you, and their links help your search ranking.

Automate the thing that wakes you up. For him it was refunds. Decide what can be refunded or answered automatically, and write the rule down.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

A crowded market. AI headshots are easy to copy. Rivals claim sharper images, faster delivery and more security certificates.

Google. A business built on search rankings depends on a single company's algorithm, and Google has been changing how it treats AI-generated pages and how much it answers questions itself.

Faces are sensitive. Customers upload photos of themselves. The company says it doesn't train on them and deletes them within 30 days. Those are its own claims, and the rules on facial data are tightening in many places.

The big models. General AI tools are getting better at realistic photos of real people. A good enough free option would hurt.

Opacity. Every number here is the company's own or somebody's estimate. That is his right, and it limits what anyone outside can know.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **More published numbers.** Whether the company says anything beyond "$10 million", or anyone outside confirms it.
2. **The team.** Who actually works there now.
3. **Quality.** Whether its own models keep ahead as everyone else's improve.
4. **The next product.** He tried four in six months once before.

He doesn't enjoy marketing and never wanted to manage people. He ended up building a business with a marketing system he only had to set up once, and he says he's glad he eventually hired.

That's File #010. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #011 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Danny Postma's podcast and press interviews, the company's own site, a vendor case study, a competitor's review and third-party estimates, each labelled as such. We haven't spoken to him or verified any revenue figure. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

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